

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN NORTH KOREA

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Concern for the environment in North Korea must be approached with unusual care and honesty, for this is the most closed nation on earth — a state where there is no independent civil society, no free press, and no space whatever for domestic environmental organising — and so this guide's central and overriding rule is that the work here runs almost entirely from outside, through the international bodies, the scientific monitoring, and the diaspora, and that anyone inside must be protected absolutely and never placed at risk. Within that hard constraint, the environmental reality that defines the country is a self-reinforcing spiral of deforestation, flood, and hunger: hillsides stripped bare for firewood in a nation of chronic energy shortage, and cleared for desperate survival-farming in a nation of chronic food shortage, so that the eroded slopes worsen the floods that ruin the crops that drive still more cutting — joined to the coal and mineral mining bound up in it, and the energy poverty that lies at its root. North Korea is a mountainous land of denuded slopes and flooding rivers, of coal and famine and cold, one of the most forest-stripped countries on earth beside a forested neighbour, a closed state whose forests were consumed, hillside by hillside, in its people's long struggle to survive. There is no domestic victory to promise. But the external tools are real.

In the most closed of nations, the tools are entirely external, and they are real. The distinctive lever is the **external scientific and satellite monitoring**: North Korea's deforestation, its coal and mineral mining, and any harmful state project can be documented from afar, beyond the state's power to hide — a record that cannot be denied. The **international bodies and frameworks** that engage North Korea, fraught and constrained as they are, carry environmental cooperation and scrutiny. The **transboundary frameworks** with its neighbours reach the shared rivers and environment — the pollution and harm that cross the borders. And the **diaspora** carries documentation and advocacy from safety. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. The country is closed and repressive beyond almost any other, so no domestic work is possible and the safety of everyone inside is paramount — never, under any circumstances, may anything be asked of anyone inside, or anyone inside be named or placed at risk. The deforestation is driven by the desperate need for food and fuel, so it can never be met with blame — only, slowly and from outside, with the humanitarian cooperation that eases the hunger and the energy poverty at its root. The flood-and-famine cycle is rooted in an unresolved crisis. The international cooperation is real but fraught and constrained. And no domestic victory is to be promised. So the work must run entirely from outside, through the international, scientific, and diaspora channels, protecting anyone inside above all else. And the honest prize is the harm monitored and documented, the mining and deforestation recorded, the transboundary harm addressed, the slow humanitarian cooperation supported — from outside, never blaming the poor, and never risking anyone inside. Above all, protect the people.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You cannot do anything inside the most closed nation on earth, and you must never try, because the danger to anyone inside is catastrophic. What can be done runs entirely from outside: monitor the deforestation, mining, and harmful projects by satellite and science, beyond the state's power to hide; engage the fraught international bodies and the transboundary frameworks with North Korea's neighbours; work through the diaspora; and support, slowly and from outside, the humanitarian cooperation that eases the hunger and fuel poverty driving the harm — never blaming the poor, and never, ever risking anyone inside.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

North Korea is the hardest and most closed setting in this entire guide, and honesty about that is the first and most absolute discipline. No domestic work is possible; the safety of everyone inside is paramount beyond all else; the deforestation is driven by desperate survival and can never be met with blame; and the international cooperation, though real, is fraught and constrained. This is not a domestic fight at all. It is external work — monitoring, international engagement, and diaspora advocacy — whose realistic prize is the harm documented and the slow humanitarian cooperation supported, while everyone inside is protected absolutely.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

All domestic power rests with a closed and total state that cannot be reached from within. The decisions an external effort can influence run through the outside: the **international bodies and frameworks** that engage North Korea; the **scientific and satellite monitors** who record the harm from afar; the **transboundary bodies** with its neighbours; and the **diaspora and international advocates**. Nothing runs through anyone inside. Map only the external channels, and never seek a contact inside, before spending a week on it.

How the Harm Moves — and Where You Jump In

The harm — the deforestation spiral, the coal and mineral mining, any harmful state project, the transboundary pollution — unfolds inside a closed state. You cannot enter it. You enter only from outside: through the satellite and scientific record that documents the harm; through the international bodies and the transboundary frameworks; and through the diaspora. And the deforestation's root — the hunger and fuel poverty — can be eased only slowly, through outside humanitarian cooperation, never through blame.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the harm from afar: the deforestation and floods the satellites record, the coal and mineral mining the imagery reveals, the transboundary pollution that crosses the borders. Follow the cooperation: the fraught international and humanitarian engagement that could ease the root causes. Follow the diaspora: the documentation and advocacy carried from safety. The leverage lies in the external monitoring, the international and transboundary frameworks, and the diaspora.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

No domestic oversight exists or can be created. The watchers are entirely external: the scientific and satellite monitors, the international bodies and frameworks, the transboundary bodies with the neighbours, and the diaspora and international advocates. These external watchers are the only ones a case can engage.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No effort achieves a domestic victory in the most closed nation on earth, and honesty requires saying so plainly. What the external tools can deliver is the harm monitored and documented, the transboundary harm addressed, and the slow humanitarian cooperation supported. The single most decisive move is **the external scientific and satellite monitoring, carried through the international and diaspora channels,**

because North Korea's deforestation and mining can be recorded from afar beyond the state's power to hide, and because these external channels risk no one inside. The satellite and scientific record is the distinctive lever; the international and transboundary frameworks the engagement; the diaspora the advocacy. The realistic prize is documentation and slow cooperation — and never, ever a risk to anyone inside.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions, all external. **What is the harm?** — the deforestation spiral, the coal or mineral mining, a harmful state project, the transboundary pollution. **What records it?** — the satellite and scientific monitoring from afar. **Which framework reaches it?** — the international bodies, the transboundary bodies with the neighbours. **What eases the root?** — the humanitarian cooperation for the hunger and fuel poverty, never blame. **How is everyone inside protected absolutely?** — the overriding question above all. Pick the harm the external monitoring can document and the external frameworks can reach, risking no one.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case entirely from outside. **Layer one: the monitored harm** — the deforestation, the mining, the floods, the transboundary pollution, documented by satellite and science from afar, beyond the state's power to hide. **Layer two: the framework** — the international bodies and the transboundary frameworks the harm engages, and the humanitarian cooperation that could ease its root. **Layer three: the safety** — the absolute discipline of never involving, naming, or risking anyone inside, and working only through the external, scientific, and diaspora channels. A case built entirely on external monitoring and framework engagement is the only kind possible here — and the only kind that keeps everyone inside safe.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **monitored record**: the satellite imagery and scientific data on the deforestation, mining, floods, and transboundary pollution. Gather the **framework record**: the international bodies and transboundary bodies that engage North Korea. Gather the **cooperation record**: the humanitarian and reforestation cooperation that eases the root causes. Gather the **diaspora record**: the documentation and advocacy from outside. Gather the **safety discipline** above all: confirm that nothing involves, names, or risks anyone inside.

STEP 3: BUILDING THE EXTERNAL AND INTERNATIONAL COALITION

The coalition here is entirely external, because no other is possible. Build it from the **scientific and satellite monitors** who record the harm from afar; the **international bodies and humanitarian agencies** that engage North Korea; the **transboundary partners** among its neighbours; and the **diaspora and international advocates**. Frame everything around the monitored harm and the humanitarian root causes, never around blame of the poor; and observe, absolutely, the rule that nothing may involve, name, prompt, or endanger anyone inside — ever.

STEP 4: THE MONITORING, THE FRAMEWORKS & THE DIASPORA — WORKING ENTIRELY FROM OUTSIDE

Set expectations honestly: the levers are entirely external and constrained, so the prize is documentation, engagement, and slow cooperation, not a domestic stop.

The External Scientific and Satellite Monitoring

The distinctive lever is the **external scientific and satellite monitoring**: North Korea's deforestation, mining, and harmful projects can be documented from afar, beyond the state's power to hide — a record that cannot be denied, gathered without risking anyone inside.

The International and Transboundary Frameworks

The **international bodies and frameworks** that engage North Korea, and the **transboundary frameworks** with its neighbours, carry environmental cooperation, scrutiny, and the addressing of the shared rivers and pollution that cross the borders. Engage them, fraught and constrained as they are.

The Diaspora and the Humanitarian Root

The **diaspora** carries documentation and advocacy from safety, and the deforestation's root — the hunger and fuel poverty — can be eased only slowly, through outside humanitarian cooperation, never through blame. Pursued together — the monitoring, the frameworks, and the diaspora and humanitarian cooperation — these external levers document the harm and, slowly, ease its root, while everyone inside is protected absolutely.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case, all externally. **For the scientific monitors**: here is deforestation, mining, or a project to document from afar. **For the international bodies**: here is a harm engaging your frameworks and cooperation. **For the transboundary partners**: here is a shared river or pollution crossing the border. **For the humanitarian agencies**: here is the hunger and fuel poverty at the root, to be eased not blamed. **For the diaspora and world**: here is the monitored harm and the human cost. **The golden rule**: work entirely from outside, ground everything in the external monitoring and frameworks, ease the root through humanitarian cooperation, never blame the poor, and never involve or risk anyone inside.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media runs entirely from outside, with the utmost care. Frame any attention around **the monitored harm and its human root**: the deforestation and floods the satellites record, the mining, the hunger and fuel poverty behind them — never around blame of the people, and never in any way that could endanger anyone inside. Carry it through the scientific findings, the international press, and the diaspora advocacy. A few cautions govern absolutely everything: never involve, name, or reference anyone inside; frame it around the monitored harm and the humanitarian root; never blame the poor; and let the satellite and scientific record carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message entirely external, science-grounded, humanitarian, and absolute in protecting everyone inside.

8A — To a scientific or satellite monitor: request or present the imagery and data on the deforestation, mining, or floods.

8B — To an international body: describe the monitored harm and the frameworks and cooperation it engages.

8C — To a transboundary partner: raise the shared river or pollution crossing the border.

8D — To a humanitarian agency: set out the hunger and fuel poverty at the root, to be eased not blamed.

8E — On the mining: present the satellite record of the coal or mineral extraction.

8F — To the diaspora: coordinate the documentation and advocacy from outside.

8G — To an international advocate: share the monitored case and request engagement.

8H — To the international public: summarise the monitored harm and its human cost — from outside, never blaming the people, never risking anyone inside.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: assemble the satellite and scientific record of the harm; write the one-page case grounded in the monitoring and the humanitarian root. **The fastest-moving levers:** the external monitoring, the international and transboundary frameworks, and the diaspora. **Emergency action:** where a harm is acute — a flood, a mining expansion — the satellite record and the international and humanitarian bodies are the sharpest, safest handles, all from outside. Throughout, involve no one inside, never blame the poor, and protect everyone absolutely.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is not merely tilted but closed absolutely, beyond any other in this guide. Recognise it plainly and accept the aim — not a domestic stop, but the harm monitored and documented, the transboundary harm addressed, the slow cooperation supported. Lean only on the external levers: the satellite and scientific monitoring, the international and transboundary frameworks, the diaspora, the humanitarian cooperation. And accept the honest limits — no domestic work is possible, the cooperation is fraught, the crisis unresolved — while still documenting the harm from outside, easing its root through humanitarian means, and protecting everyone inside absolutely.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL REPRESSION — AND WHO IS AT RISK

Here the danger is not hidden corruption but a total, repressive state where any perceived dissent can bring catastrophic consequences to a person and their family. Respond only through the **entirely external channels:** the monitoring, the international and transboundary frameworks, the diaspora, the humanitarian cooperation. Never through anything inside. **On safety and protection:** this note matters more here than almost anywhere in this series, and governs absolutely everything. North Korea is the most closed and repressive of states. Work only through the international, cooperation, scientific, and diaspora channels,

entirely from outside; never, under any circumstances, ask anything of anyone inside, name anyone inside, or prompt any domestic action; and protect everyone inside with an absoluteness beyond even the other hard cases in this guide. Protection is the one inviolable rule.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, entirely from outside. The satellite and scientific record feeds the international engagement, the transboundary case, and the diaspora advocacy at once; the humanitarian cooperation runs slowly beneath it all; nothing touches anyone inside. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, assemble the monitored record of the harm; **months two onward**, engage the international bodies, the transboundary partners, and the diaspora, and support the humanitarian cooperation; **through the long, slow effort**, sustain the documentation and the easing of the root causes. The core discipline: entirely external, monitored, humanitarian, and absolute in protecting everyone inside.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

North Korea is the hardest and most closed ground in this entire guide, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim any domestic work is possible, or that a domestic victory exists, or that the poor who cut and farm to survive can be blamed — none of that is true, and the danger to anyone inside is catastrophic. What it claims is narrow and real: that North Korea's deforestation, mining, and harmful projects can be documented from afar by satellite and science, beyond the state's power to hide; that the international bodies and the transboundary frameworks with its neighbours carry fraught but real engagement; that the diaspora carries documentation and advocacy from safety; and that the hunger and fuel poverty at the root can be eased, slowly and from outside, through humanitarian cooperation that never blames the poor. The levers are entirely external, and the prize is the harm monitored and documented, the transboundary harm addressed, and the slow cooperation supported — never a domestic stop, and never a risk to anyone inside. For the most closed nation on earth, that entirely external work — monitored, humanitarian, and absolute in protecting everyone inside — is not a lesser ambition. It is the only possible and responsible one.